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“My Perfect Feet”
Andy Hobin

(A horribly disfigured man enters and slowly addresses the audience.)

ROBERT

I was sitting in my squad car at a red light when an intoxicated motorist rear-ended me at 40 miles an hour, and my car went up in flames. I was stuck inside that steel fireball for two minutes. Count that. One… two… three… I survived that. My body was covered with third and fourth degree burn. Fourth. When I was a Boy Scout, I was taught that there were only three degrees of burns. Fourth – apparently subject matter too troubling for a young boy’s mind to have to contemplate. I survived that. Lucky me.

(He contemplatively massages his shoulder.) I endured over thirty hours of surgery that first week. Surgery on *everything*. You see these two fingers? These two finger were actually fused together before a doctor had them surgically separated. People hear about something like my fingers and they usually ask me something along the lines of, “Did it hurt when your fingers were stuck together?” To which I would respond, “…No. Actually, it helped me swim a little faster. *(He chuckles.)* I always try to tell a joke. Makes people feel more comfortable when they talk to me. That’s the same reason I tell them about my feet. *(He smiles broadly.)* My feet were completely untouched by the flames. They’re perfect. They’re actually part of the reason I’m here. See, a couple of weeks after the accident they finally let my wife, Maura, in to see me. And I was wrapped head to toe in bandages, I couldn’t speak, I was just… there. And Maura’s making small talk and I hear her getting closer to the bed as she’s speaking… and then she stops and for a second all there is is just the blip… blip… blip… of the heart monitor. And suddenly she kneeling and weeping and clutching my feet. She just kept saying “I love you. I love you. I love you so much…” I felt her tears on my bare feet like… like she was washing my feet. And I knew right then that I was going to get through this. And I was going to do it for her. Well.

Three months and multiple, multiple surgeries later, I come home, and everyone’s calling me a “hero!” And an “inspiration!”

And I’m thinking to myself, hot damn! You know? I mean, I didn’t go to college, I didn’t vote in the last election, hell, this one time back in the day, some guy was talking shit about a girl I was running around with, so I slipped a bunch of Visine in his beer. Visine has a chemical in it that is an extremely *potent* laxative. And I’m the “inspiration!” You see, it’s still me. Still the same old Robert, oh that crazy friggin’ Robert… Still me. I’m just trapped under this layer of scars. Still me, but I can understand why Kelly, my five year old daughter, acted… the way that she did.

We tried to prepare her for me the best would could, Maura and me, really we did. But I don’t know what hurt worse: her crying and crying and crying, or that look on her face like she could not believe that it was me under that skin. Like she didn’t even recognize me. That first day she hid herself away, and I felt bad for her, you know? So I let her hide. Figured she’s come out when she was ready. Well, three days later and still no contact from my little girl, I had had enough. So that night after Maura put her to bed, I went into her room and sat down in the dark, and I said, “Kelly, honey, are you still afraid of me? And she said, “Just don’t turn the light on, Daddy.” It was okay to talk just as long as we left the light off. I just… it felt so *good* to be able to hear about her day, what she did at recess, what she had for lunch, all that little stuff. But I still felt like I was on the outside looking in. Like I was looking through glass. Look, but don’t touch. That’s what really got to me.

And Maura. One night in bed, I reached over and put my hand on her back, and she jumped when I touched her. She just smiled and said that I surprised her, but I couldn’t help but wonder if was the sheer element of surprise itself, *(He regards his hand.)* or the feeling of my rough, coarse skin against her bare back. And how do you know?!

This went on. Talking to my daughter in the dark, never knowing if my wife is repulsed by my touch, and one day I woke, went into the bathroom, looked in the mirror and realized that this is it. For the rest of my life, people will be polite when they speak to me and stare as I walk away, and I can rehabilitate my body, but never my place in the world. There were the pills, right there in the medicine cabinet, but I couldn’t do it. Not yet. So I go down to the kitchen to get a drink and as I’m opening the refrigerator, something catches my eye. *(He pulls a small remote from his pocket, aims it into the audience, and gives it a click. A simple crayon drawing of a mother, father, and daughter is projected over the wall.)* It was this picture,

with yesterday’s date on it. Mommy, Kelly… and Daddy. Look at me. I’m just Daddy again. No scars, nothing. And suddenly Kelly’s standing there, I didn’t see her come in, and she says, “Do you like it, Daddy?” I can hardly speak. I say, “Yes honey, very much, it’s very beautiful.” And she smiles and walks out of the kitchen. That was the first time since coming home that my daughter has spoken to me outside of her dark room. I looked at that picture and I knew right then that my baby girl loved me. And I looked down at my feet - my beautiful, beautiful bare feet – and I remembered feeling my wife’s tears, and I knew that we are not only put here on this earth, but *kept* here for a purpose. People still stare. I mean, that’s the inevitable. But you… you. You talk to me. You look past the scars and you learn my purpose. I have my life because I have my love. And I am so very alive. I am alive.